

FIELD OF VISION **ISHARDA UGRA**

All In the Air

If you do catch the All India Radio (AIR) commentary of the India-England Test series, it will seem a mixed blessing. On AIR, fours are not mere boundaries, but 'BSNL chaukaas'. One commentator even sports an unfortunate, wannabe Aussie accent through which Sehwag becomes "Say-wag" and Dhoni is called "Doney". But listening to the Chennai Test live will still be a blessing because this year, for the first time in 60 years of live cricket commentary, AIR fell silent during two home Test series: India vs South Africa and the last crackling India vs Australia contest.

The AIR HQ in Delhi says every effort is made to "serve the listeners" but in the two cases mentioned, negotiations with rights holder Nimbus had proved intractable. Nimbus, AIR officials hinted, was asking for far too much. AIR has a monopoly on broadcasting cricket commentary in India, so rather than be financially squeezed, they have the upper hand in all rights negotiations. Nimbus officials have confirmed that AIR did not approach them for rights of the Tests against Australia or South Africa.

The Sports Broadcasting Signals (Mandatory Sharing with Prasar Bharati) Bill, 2007, (which allowed Doordarshan's terrestrial service to piggyback on rights holders for all international matches played in India), applies to radio too. Yet, AIR has steered clear of any revenue-sharing agreement with rights holders (a key clause in the Bill), paying a flat broadcast fee in the range of Rs 2 lakh a match. But obviously as Tests are not as lucrative as ODIs, they have slipped under AIR's radar.

AIR's overall approach is killing cricket on radio—as skill, option and enterprise. The entire 2007 World Cup in the Caribbean was broadcast off television, with commentators in a Delhi studio being instructed to describe fictitious swaying palms and gentle breezes. But why bother with cricket on radio at all as it is TV that pulls in all

the bucks? Because radio reaches 99.14 per cent of Indians, including millions on the move. There are at least 125 million radio sets in India (television homes are estimated at 100 million). Listeners with access to every set could range from a household of four to a gang of ten around a *paanwalla*.

Commentator and columnist Harsha Bhogle, who began his career as an AIR commentator, says, "If you have a development objective, you can't be saying that you're only going to concentrate on those programmes that make money for you. "At a recent visit to a school for the visually challenged, a student, disappointed by the lack of Test commentary asked Bhogle, "What about us? How do we see matches?"

Perhaps, AIR's bosses have an answer for him.



WON: By golfer Jeev Milkha Singh, the Golf Nippon Series JT Cup in Tokyo, Japan. This is his fourth title of the season.

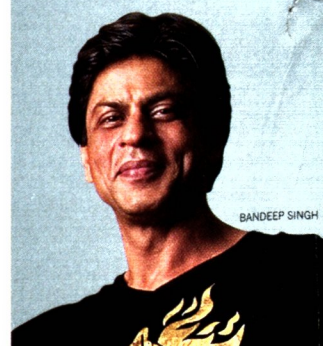
SUMET INDER SINGH



DIED: Rambhau Rambhaji Sawant, Congress leader and freedom fighter. He was 90. He was part of the Freedom Movement from 1939 to 1942.

APPOINTED: Rajiv Mathur, 59, as the new director of the Intelligence Bureau. He will take over from P.C. Haldar. Mathur is a 1972 batch IPS officer of the Uttar Pradesh cadre who has served in the Intelligence Bureau for nearly three years.

CONFERRED: On actor Shah Rukh Khan, the Darjah Mulia Seri Melaka or Datuk by the Malaysian government. The award is the equivalent to British Knighthood and was awarded to Khan for boosting tourism in Malaysia through his movies.



BANDEEP SINGH



R.I.P

SAURABH SINGH